



Photograph: Mexy Xavier Imaging: Neeta Wadiker

received a tremendous response when it was launched in the late 1990s and continues to be popular with many publishing houses.

In this comparison test, we included only those DTP software that had the functionality of layers, text wrapping, frames, masking, etc. Corel Ventura has been a favourite with many, but we weren't able to include it in our comparison test because it was unavailable.

SOFTWARE SPEAK

Interface

A reasonably appealing look and feel of the interface adds to the tool's intuitive feel. Software developers conveniently ignore this factor and as

a result what one gets is an extremely functional product with an extremely dull interface. Shortcuts allow for easy access to commonly used features from the keyboard. A good software will not only have the facility of providing this feature, but also the capability of customising shortcuts. If a user wants a particular shortcut through a particular set of keys, he should be able to do so.

Toolbars are perhaps the most commonly accessed element in a page layout software. The toolbar should have the common set of tools so that the user does not have to access the menu each time to use the feature. Software developers have started placing the extra functions of a particular tool in the toolbar, but in a hidden mode, which can only be accessed when it is double-clicked. Users will be more appreciative of the floating toolbar as it gives them the flexibility of dragging and dropping.

A common problem with professional software available today is too many choices. Users are often stuck with features they can't use. Therefore, it is important for a software to explain the basic operations through adequate help and documentation and give in-depth examples, information which would really be helpful to new users.

In spite of the release of the new PageMaker, the Adobe developers seem to not have taken many pains to improve the interface. It looks no different from its previous version with the exception of a quick access toolbar under the menu bar, which can be called a nice addition. QuarkXPress has a simple but not appealing interface like Adobe InDesign. It too features a floating toolbar with a common set of tools like frames, Bezier, selection, type and drawing tools.

Microsoft Publisher's interface might not appeal to a professional user. It too has a floating tool palette that, by default, is stuck on the left-hand side of the software. You will not have to manually pick and drag the bar and place it wherever you need it. A wizard panel also appears on the left-hand side but it gives the impression of the screen being too cramped. You can hide it though.

Adobe Frame Maker's interface is shocking; it is difficult to believe that Adobe has developed this software. This has a highly unintuitive interface and the toolbar looks very dull indeed. One wonders why this is so after the proven brilliance of other Adobe products such as Photoshop, Illustrator, etc.

InDesign, with an interface similar to that of Adobe Illustrator, possesses a common set of tools like the gradient, free transform, text, drawing, eyedropper, etc, which make it a pleasure to work with this software. Both Adobe InDesign and Frame Maker boast a good set of help files which

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